What You've Done

In this chapter you saw how Rails provides fixtures as an exceptionally simple way to create a set of test data that can be shared across multiple tests. However, fixtures are so simple that they tend to not be adaptable to more complex product needs. Factory tools, which take a little bit more initial setup, allow for more flexibility at some cost in test performance. The two structures are not mutually exclusive. One pattern for combining them is to create a complex scenario in fixtures for use in integration or complex controller tests, and to use factories for unit tests or simpler controller tests.

Fixtures and factory tools allow you to get test data into your database to create a known baseline for testing. However, in some cases you may not want to place data in the database. Using the database in a test may be undesirable for performance reasons, for philosophical reasons (some people don't consider it reasonable to touch the database in a "unit" test), or where logistical reasons make objects hard to create. In the next chapter you'll explore test doubles, which allow tests to proceed by faking not the data but rather the method calls that produce the data.